

“Dulce et Decorum Est”

Wilfred Owen

Born in Shropshire, England in 1893, Wilfred Owen is the most well-known and most highly regarded of the World War I poets. He enlisted in the army in 1915 and fought in France. In May 1917, he was evacuated from the front and hospitalized with shell shock (a condition now referred to as post-traumatic stress disorder). He returned to the battlefield and won the Military Cross in October 1918. Five of his poems were published that year—the only five he lived to see in print. His work exposes the horrors of the war firsthand. He was killed in battle one week before the armistice. Owen’s work remained virtually unknown until 1920, when his friend, Siegfried Sassoon, collected his work and published it as Poems. Although Owen’s life was short, and his career as a writer even shorter, his influence on the next generation of British writers was profound. While recovering from shell shock, he drafted what was to become one of the most famous and gripping poems about war in the English language, “Dulce et Decorum Est.” The title comes from the Roman poet Horace (65-8 B.C.E.), whose line “Dulce et decorum est pro patria mori” means “It is sweet and fitting to die for one’s country” in Latin.

- Bent double, like old beggars under sacks,
Knock-kneed, coughing like hags, we cursed through sludge,
Till on the haunting flares we turned our backs,
And towards our distant rest began to trudge.
- 5 Men marched asleep. Many had lost their boots,
But limped on, blood-shod. All went lame; all blind;
Drunk with fatigue; deaf even to the hoots
Of gas-shells dropping softly behind.
- 10 Gas! GAS! Quick, boys!—An ecstasy of fumbling
Fitting the clumsy helmets just in time,
But someone still was yelling out and stumbling
And flound’ring like a man in fire or lime.—
Dim through the misty panes and thick green light,
As under a green sea, I saw him drowning.
- 15 In all my dreams before my helpless sight,
He plunges at me, guttering, choking, drowning.
- 20 If in some smothering dreams, you too could pace
Behind the wagon that we flung him in,
And watch the white eyes writhing in his face,
His hanging face, like a devil’s sick of sin;
If you could hear, at every jolt, the blood
Come gargling from the froth-corrupted lungs,
Obscene as cancer, bitter as the cud
Of vile, incurable sores on innocent tongues,—
- 25 My friend, you would not tell with such high zest
To children ardent for some desperate glory,
The old Lie: Dulce et decorum est
Pro patria mori.